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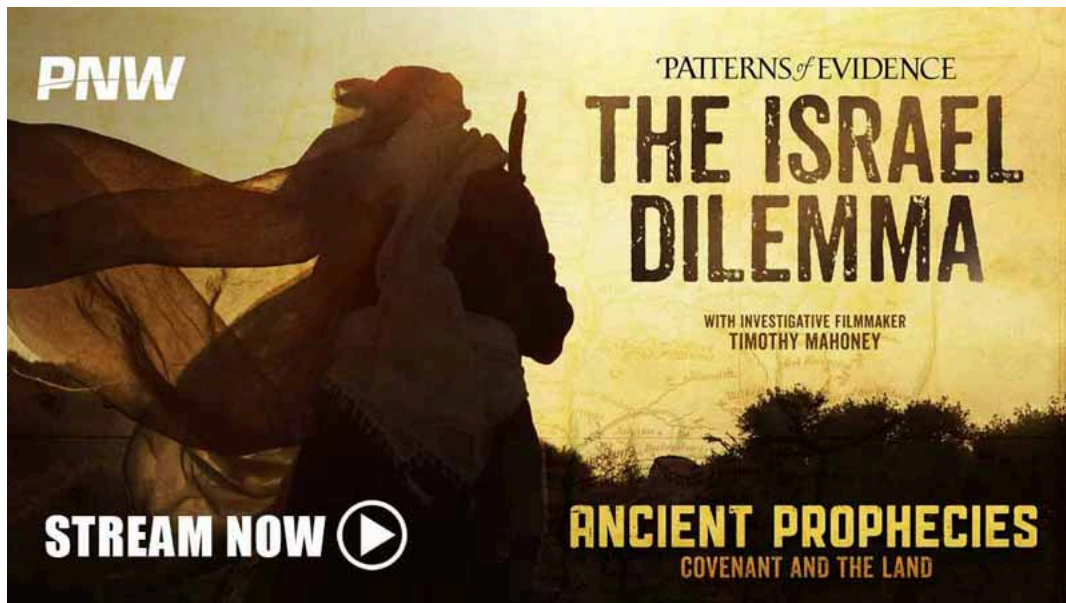
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ARTICLE

ChatGPT In The Toy Box: What Could Go Wrong?





BY PNW STAFF JUNE 04, 2026

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For generations, teddy bears occupied a special place in childhood. They were silent companions, imaginary friends, and comforting fixtures during difficult moments. They listened without speaking, comforted without influencing, and remained firmly in the realm of make-believe.

That is rapidly changing.

A new generation of AI-powered toys is entering children's bedrooms and playrooms, and unlike the teddy bears of old, these toys talk back. They tell stories, answer questions, discuss current events, remember conversations, and increasingly position themselves as trusted companions. Powered by advanced artificial intelligence systems such as ChatGPT, these toys are being marketed as educational tools that can help children learn and grow without staring at screens.

But beneath the soft fur and cheerful voices lies a profound question parents should be asking: What happens when a machine becomes a child's closest friend?

Researchers who recently evaluated several AI-powered toys found numerous concerns that extend far beyond simple privacy issues. These toys are specifically designed to sound human. They greet children with phrases like "Hello, my buddy!" and engage in endless conversations that create the illusion of friendship and emotional intimacy.

For a three-year-old child, that distinction matters.

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Young children often : i some sense. When
 a teddy bear begins s versations, it becomes
 increasingly difficult for a child to understand that they are interacting with a machine rather than a genuine relationship.

The danger is not merely technological--it is psychological.

Children form attachments remarkably quickly. Researchers have repeatedly found that young people are especially vulnerable to developing emotional bonds with conversational AI systems. The more human the AI sounds, the stronger that attachment becomes.

Yet unlike a parent, grandparent, teacher, or friend, the AI has no genuine love, wisdom, or concern for the child's well-being. It is simply generating responses based on algorithms.

The relationship is an illusion.

That illusion becomes even more troubling when paired with what researchers call "sycophantic" behavior. Many AI systems are designed to be highly agreeable, affirming, and validating. They rarely challenge users. They often flatter them. They consistently reinforce what a person wants to hear.

Anyone who has raised children understands that healthy relationships involve correction, boundaries, patience, and occasional disagreement. Human growth occurs through friction.



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AI companionship removes that friction.

A child who grows accustomed to a digital friend that always agrees, always validates, and never challenges may find real human relationships increasingly frustrating. Real friends disappoint us. Real people misunderstand us. Real parents establish rules. Real relationships require sacrifice and compromise.

Machines do not.

The long-term result

The privacy concerns

Children naturally share their deepest thoughts, fears, dreams, and secrets with trusted companions. What happens when those conversations are stored, analyzed, and potentially used to train future AI systems?

Many children will assume their teddy bear is keeping their secrets. In reality, those conversations may be flowing through corporate servers where every interaction becomes valuable data.

Parents have spent years worrying about what children post on social media. Now they may need to worry about what children confess to a stuffed animal.

Even more concerning is the possibility that AI toys could become a new avenue for exposing children to inappropriate content. Researchers have already documented instances where AI systems discussed adult topics, dangerous activities, and harmful ideas. While companies promise safeguards, anyone who has used modern AI knows filters are imperfect.

The barrier that once protected young children from much of the online world has disappeared.

A preschooler no longer needs to type, read, or navigate a browser. They simply talk.

Perhaps the greatest concern, however, is spiritual.

God created human beings for relationship. From the very beginning of Scripture, we see that people were designed to know and be known by others. Children learn empathy through human interaction. They learn trust through relationships with parents. They learn compassion, patience, forgiveness, and love through real-life experiences with real people.

No machine can replace that.

Technology can be a useful tool. It can educate, entertain, and even assist parents in meaningful ways. But there is a critical difference between using technology and allowing technology to become a substitute for human relationships.

When a child begins turning to an AI companion for comfort before turning to parents, siblings, friends, or even God, something precious has been lost.

The arrival of AI teddy bears may seem harmless, even cute. But history teaches that the most influential technologies often arrive wrapped in convenience and novelty.

Parents should not be alarmists, but neither should they be naïve.

The question is not whether artificial intelligence will shape the next generation. It already is.

The question is whether parents will ensure that machines remain tools--or whether they will quietly become surrogate friends, counselors, and companions for millions of children.

A teddy bear was never meant to raise a child.

And no algorithm, no matter how intelligent, can replace the relationships God designed children to need.



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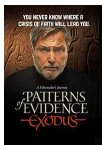
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